

Colors range from golden-hued *Humulus lupulus* 'Aureus' to the deep green of many jasmines, as well as the purple tints of plants such as *Vitis vinifera* 'Purpurea'. Others have bright, variegated foliage, such as *Actinidia kolomikta*, with its green leaves tipped with splashes of cream and pink. Some, most notably species of vitis and parthenocissus, produce their finest displays in fall when both fire up with burning shades of red.

Climbers such as passion flowers (*Passiflora*) and clematis bear beautiful flowers, while some, especially wisteria, honeysuckles (*Lonicera*), and jasmines, are deliciously fragrant. The flower colors span the spectrum from the creamy whites of *Schizophragma integrifolium* and *Hydrangea petiolaris* to the magentas of bougainvillea, the blues and purples of a whole range of clematis, and the chocolate-maroon of *Rhodochiton atrosanguineus*. With many climbers their season is further prolonged by silky seed heads, as in clematis or striking berries, notably the oblong, purple fruits of *Billardiera longiflora* and the orange-yellow fruits of *Celastrus orbiculatus*.

Annual climbers such as sweet peas (*Lathyrus odoratus*) climb rapidly to the top of wigwams made from garden canes, producing a succession of scented flowers from mid- to late summer that are ideal for cutting. Morning glory (*Ipomoea tricolor* 'Heavenly blue'), with its sky-blue trumpets

and black-eyed Susan (*Thunbergia alata*), also offer a quick-fix solution, covering a trellis or adding height to containers on patios.

Wall shrubs are also valued for their attractive foliage and blooms. Ceanothus, for example, has both evergreen and deciduous forms, with flowers in varying shades of blue, white, and pink. The flowering quince (*Chaenomeles*) produces a profusion of cupped white, pink, orange, or scarlet-red flowers early in the year, followed by yellow fruits in the fall. Thorny pyracanthas make excellent security hedges, deterring intruders, and sport glossy evergreen foliage with an abundance of yellow, orange, or red berries in the fall.

Designing with climbers and wall shrubs

Growing climbers as a backdrop for other plants is one way of adding height to a border, but they can also be grown on freestanding supports to form screens or divisions between different parts of the garden. Grown through trees or on pillars and pyramids, they also create focal points.

Where a garden lacks shade, climbers allowed to ramble over pergolas and arbors offer a cool place to sit. You can also use climbers and wall shrubs to soften the lines of hard landscaping, while vigorous climbers will help to camouflage unsightly structures. Left unsupported, some climbers trail on the ground and, when pegged at the



ABOVE Clematis 'Bill MacKenzie'

This small-bloomed, late-flowering Group 3 clematis provides a natural, rambling backdrop of nodding yellow flowers and fluffy seedheads.

nodes, will root to form a carpet of ground cover. When growing climbers through other plants, make sure that you synchronize their flowering times for a dual effect, and match their pruning needs.

As well as growing shrubs such as pyracanthas and chaenomeles against walls, you can train them into fans and espaliers for a formal effect.

PRUNING CLEMATIS

Some clematis flower well if pruned lightly or not at all, while others bloom more effectively when cut back hard. They are divided into three groups, each with different pruning requirements. Group 1 clematis (including *C. montana*, and *C. armandii*) are vigorous plants that flower in late spring on the previous year's growth. Group 2 clematis, such as

C. 'Corona', and *C. 'Henryi'*, flower in early summer on the previous year's growth. Group 3 clematis include small-flowered viticella and texensis types, such as *C. 'Gravetye Beauty'*, and some large-flowered types including *C. 'Perle d'Azur'*. They bloom from midsummer to fall on new growth formed earlier in the year.



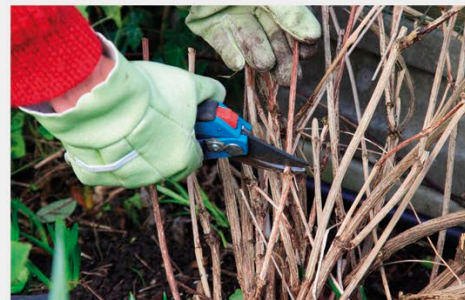
Pruning Group 1 clematis

Plants in this group need little or no pruning once established, except to remove dead and damaged stems, or to keep them in check. After flowering, give them a light trim if necessary. Prune the leggy new season's growth, cutting above a pair of healthy buds, but do not cut them back hard.



Pruning Group 2 clematis

Prune this group in early spring when the buds are in growth and are clearly visible. Work from the top of the clematis, pruning each stem back to the first pair of healthy buds or shoots. Remove dead, diseased, or damaged wood; it will be brown and dry. The pruned stems will produce new growth and then flowers in early summer.



Pruning Group 3 clematis

Left unpruned, these clematis form flowers at the top of the plant, leaving bare, straggly stems at the bottom. In late winter before the buds break, remove the tangle of shoots from their support and cut back all the stems hard to within 12in (30cm) of the ground. This encourages strong new shoots and flowers to form along their length.